



Unit 9: The Role and Responsibilities of a Project Manager

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1. The Role and Responsibilities of a Project Manager

Introduction to the Unit

In this unit, we will learn about the *Role and Responsibilities* of a *Project Manager*.

We will focus on understanding why the *Project Manager* needs to juggle several responsibilities at the same time—something that requires higher-order leadership qualities and excellent communication and interpersonal skills.

We will closely examine the various *Responsibilities* that need to be shouldered by the *Project Manager* and the specific *Skills* that are required to effectively discharge such responsibilities.

Objectives

Upon completion of this unit, you will be able to:

- Describe the role and responsibilities of a *Project Manager*
- Identify the characteristics of an effective *Project Manager*



The Role and Responsibilities of a Project Manager

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Objectives

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Introduction

In the last segment, we learned about the project closure phase and the various activities performed therein. In this segment, we will focus on the role and responsibilities of a *Project Manager* and various characteristics necessary for this role.

The *Project Manager's* role is critical in determining the success or failure of a project. This role carries much authority and even more responsibility. The *Project Manager* is responsible for the smooth operations and transition from one stage of the project life cycle to the next.

The incumbent is answerable to the *Stakeholders* for providing updates on the project progress as well as timely escalations in case of any foreseeable delays or threats. In this way, the role of the *Project Manager* is a pivot on which the entire project rests.

The basic prerequisite for this role is communication skills. The *Project Manager* will have to constantly interact with the various *Stakeholders* of the project. It could be the *Clients*, the *Sponsor*, the *Team Members*, and sometime the end users the organisational support team and many others.

The *Project Manager* needs to involve them and be aware of what is happening in the project and how all *Stakeholders'* support can be obtained to make the project successful.

The *Project Manager* should have absolute and strong focus on the goals of the project as the project's success is inseparably connected with its goals. The *Project Manager* needs to apply all the tools and techniques available to ensure that the project is successfully completed and delivered.

Therefore, he/she should be skilled enough to define and drive the project and must be aware of all the organisational processes and support systems.

Characteristics of an Effective Project Manager

While different Project Managers may have varying levels of managerial skills and leadership styles depending on their unique experiences in various industries, there are some key skills that are invariably found in all successful Project Managers across industries and geographical demarcations. Some of these are listed below.



Communication skills

We began this discussion by mentioning communication skills as an essential quality of a Project Manager—we cannot emphasize this enough! This skill is not just about talking to stakeholders but also about:

- communicating effectively when the need arises,
- escalating risks and problems in a timely manner to the relevant stakeholders,
- scheduling meetings and driving them properly,
- providing status reports to the *Stakeholders*, and
- listening to and understanding the *Stakeholders'* expectations.

Team building skills

It is the ability to build an effective team which can deliver results. Building an effective team is not just about getting the right resources and putting them to work but also involves making each resource work as a team.

A motivated team can do wonders for a project. It can even make a complex or difficult project a successful one. A *Project Manager* needs to understand every *Team Member*, their motivational needs and ensure that they are always ready to accept work and complete it without compromising on the quality. In long and complex projects, it often proves a challenge to keep the team motivated enough to deliver consistently. It requires a delicate balancing act by the *Project Manager* who needs to be sufficiently self-motivated to drive the team to deliver.

Conflict management skills

Where human beings are working together, we are bound to have conflicts. It could be a conflict of ideas, thoughts, implementation, working style, adapting to process and so on. The *Project Manager* needs to provide proper direction to the team and manage the conflicts using effective conflict resolution skills.

Conflict management is about understanding the disagreement between affected parties, setting up meetings to discuss each party's view and arriving at a solution, which helps in taking the project forward. There are various techniques available for managing conflicts which a *Project Manager* can use.

Time management skills

Most of the time, the *Project Manager's* role is like that of a juggler trying to ensure he does not drop any of the balls on the ground. This may conjure up the image of a clown or a juggler in the circus who is entralling the audience with his expert timing and jugglery skills.

This sort of an artist is actually not a clown, but a skilled professional who knows how to stay focused. Timing is of essence in this delicate art.

The *Project Manager* needs to juggle with many action items on his plate, all of which need to be completed. He has to prioritise and plan his tasks and use his time efficiently to ensure that those activities are completed properly.

He needs to efficiently manage his own time and also ensure that the team is neither wasting time nor spending too much of this limited resource.



Industry and solution knowledge

A generic *Project Manager* who has an understanding of project management is good enough. However, a *Project Manager* who speaks the language of people involved can work more efficiently and drive them to deliver more.

Take the example of a *Project Manager* who has been in the manufacturing machines industry for many years. One fine day, he is asked to manage a project which is to build a software tool for a bank.

He could be initially lost but since the project management process is essentially the same across all industries, he can still manage. However, it takes time to understand the jargon and the terms and nomenclature in the new project.

While managing projects which belong to a different domain, the *Project Manager* will have to face the initial learning curve. Therefore, having the background of that industry and the solution knowledge will immensely help the *Project Manager* to get into the skin of the project quickly and focus on delivering.

The *Project Manager's* role and responsibilities in each project or organisation may vary. Table 13 shows the generic roles and responsibilities a *Project Manager* in any given project.

Table 13: Role and Responsibilities of a Project Manager

Phase	Role/Responsibilities
Initiation	• Project definition: Document high-level project scope, timeline and budget. Obtain project Sponsor's approval and sign-off for the project definition. • Identification of project Stakeholders, their roles and responsibilities. • Performing feasibility studies.
Planning	• Develop, assess and select a proper strategy for the project, considering performance, cost, time and scope constraints. • Create project schedule based on: ○ Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) ○ Time and budget estimates • Create a responsibilities document for all members • Develop a: • communication plan • risk management plan • procurement plan • issue management plan, and • quality management plan
Execution, Monitor and	• Conduct kick-off meeting



Project Management

Control	• Direct and execute the approved plan • Monitor project execution • Control and monitor project scope, time, cost, quality and risk • Change management • Report on project performance • Manage <i>Stakeholders</i> expectations • Administer procurement
Closure	• Gather lessons learned • Close procurement

At the organisational level, the *Project Manager*'s role must be recognised and granted appropriate authority and accountability.

The *Project Sponsor* should provide the *Project Manager* with such authority as stated in the project charter document and reiterated in a kick-off meeting where key *Stakeholders* directly involved in the project are present.

The amount of time the *Team Members* commit to the project should be negotiated between the *Project Manager* and the functional managers to whom the *Team Members* directly report in the case of functionally structured organisation.

As a general rule, the *Project Manager* must be capable of interacting effectively with people. This involves having leadership, communication, negotiation and team building skills. A successful *Project Manager* needs to be prepared to resolve conflict and demonstrate interpersonal communication skills and have the goals of the project in focus.

Summary

In this segment, you learned that:

- the *Project Manager* is a key role in project management and represents the pivot on which the entire project rests, and
- some of the essential characteristics of a *Project Manager* are communication skills, team building skills, time management skills, conflict management skills and industry and solution knowledge.